to being sure. Horowitz and I gave NASA scientists the coordinates of our fleeting and enigmatic events. Perhaps they would be able to confirm and clarify our results. The NASA program was also developing new technology, stimulating ideas, and exciting schoolchildren. In the eyes of many it was well worth the $10 million a year being spent on it. But almost exactly a year after authorizing it, Congress pulled the plug on NASA's SETI program. It cost too much, they said. The post—Cold War U.S. defense budget is some 30,000 times larger.

The chief argument of the principal opponent of the NASA SETI program—Senator Richard Bryan of Nevada—was this [from the *Congressional Record* for September 22, 1993]:

> So far, the NASA SETI Program has found nothing. In fact, all the decades of SETI research have found no confirmable signs of extraterrestrial life.
>
> Even with the current NASA version of SETI, I do not think many of its scientists would be willing to guarantee that we are likely to see any tangible results in the [foreseeable] future …
>
> Scientific research rarely, if ever, offers guarantees of success—and I understand that —and the full benefits of such research are often unknown until very late in the process. And I accept that, as well.
>
> In the case of SETI, however, the chances of success are so remote, and the likely benefits of the program are so limited, that there is little justification for 12 million taxpayer dollars to be expended for this program.

But how, before we have found extraterrestrial intelligence, can we "guarantee" that we will find it? How, on the other hand, can we know that the chances of success are "remote"? And if we find extraterrestrial intelligence, are the benefits really likely to be "so limited"? As in all great exploratory ventures, we do not know what we will find and we don't know the probability of finding it. If we did, we would not have to look.

SETI is one of those search programs irritating to those who want well-defined cost/benefit ratios. Whether ETI can be found; how long it would take to find it; and what it would cost to do so are all unknown. The benefits might be enormous, but we can't really be